ship ore at cost from Brazilian mines, which were amongst the best in the world. But he wanted the steel plants for virtually nothing, says Muthuraman, who was present at the meeting. The proposal, which was made to avoid a bidding war, consequently yielded little to none.

As the news of the Tatas' interactions with Corus became public, on 5 October, Tata Steel confirmed that it was looking at various acquisition opportunities, including Corus. The admission drew reactions from many quarters. Some commented that the Tata Group was overreaching. The *International Herald Tribune* termed the attempt as analogous to 'a minnow swallowing a whale'.

Ratan was, however, undeterred. On 12 October, the Tata Steel board met and approved the presentation of a 'indicative non binding offer' to Corus to acquire 100 per cent equity of the Anglo-Dutch entity. On 17 October 2006, through a press release, Tata Steel confirmed that it had made the offer. While the Tatas' bid came as a relief for the troubled Corus shareholders, it also led to reports of counter bids from rival steel companies worldwide.

On 20 October, a special board meeting of Tata Steel was held at St James' Court Hotel at 6 a.m. It was to be an important day for the group. Ratan had taken a night flight from the US and arrived at the crack of dawn.

Without waiting to rest, he rushed for the meeting. Nusli Wadia, Ishaat Hussain, J.J. Irani, B. Muthuraman, Tridibesh Mukherjee and A.N. Singh were in attendance. Five others, including Soonawala, Tata Sons' Executive Director Arun Gandhi, Koushik Chatterjee and two others joined via a video link. During this special meeting, only issues connected with the Tatas' bid for Corus were discussed. After some deliberation, it was decided to make a formal offer to buy Corus through its newly incorporated UK company, Tata Steel UK Limited.

During the meeting, Ratan made it clear that there would be no formal quote until the entire board was in favour of the proposal. 'If anybody has the slightest hesitation, I will not go through with it,' Hussain recalls him telling everyone. 'He went from chair to chair. It was a conscious decision. It was a collective decision.' It was a tense meeting. A decision had to be taken quickly as any offer had to be communicated to the London Stock Exchange before it opened at 8 a.m., Hussain adds.

The board unanimously approved the proposed all-cash purchase of 100 per cent of the shares at a cost of 455 pence per share, valuing Corus at £4.3